Laboratory 03 Report: PCA and LDA

Machine Learning and Pattern Recognition

1 Project section

2 PCA analysis

What do you observe from the PCA projected histograms? What are the effects on the class distribution?

Applying Principal Component Analysis (PCA) transforms the dataset by projecting it onto a new set of orthogonal axes ordered by their variance. Observing the histograms of the projected features, the first PCA direction (Direction 1) captures the maximum overall spread of the dataset. As we move towards Direction 6, the variance noticeably decreases.

However, the effect on the class distribution reveals a crucial limitation of unsupervised dimensionality reduction. Both the "Fake" (label 0) and "Genuine" (label 1) classes span across the entire range of these new axes and heavily overlap. Because PCA maximizes the total variance of the data regardless of class labels, the direction of maximum data spread does not align with the direction of maximum class discrimination. The distributions morph into largely unimodal shapes, but they do not separate.

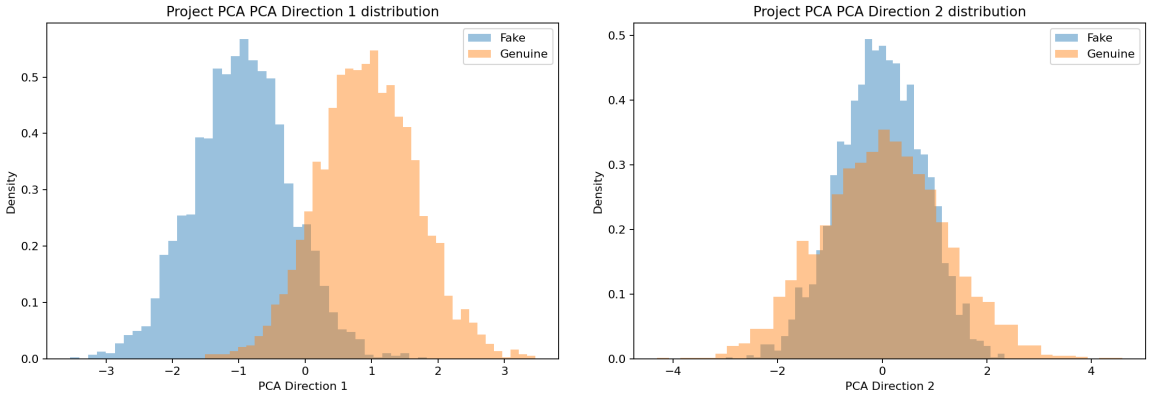


Figure 1: Histograms of the data projected onto the first two PCA directions. Notice the heavy overlap between the Fake and Genuine classes despite the high overall variance.

Can you spot the different clusters inside each class? Have the clusters really changed? Have the classes really become "more separated"?

No, the clusters have not changed, and the classes have not become more separated.

Applying PCA and retaining all $m = 6$ dimensions acts mathematically as a rigid orthogonal rotation of the original feature space. Because an orthogonal transformation perfectly preserves Euclidean distances (L_2 norm), any two data points that were overlapping or close together in the raw feature space remain exactly the same distance apart in the PCA-transformed space. We are simply viewing the exact same geometric structure from a newly rotated coordinate system.

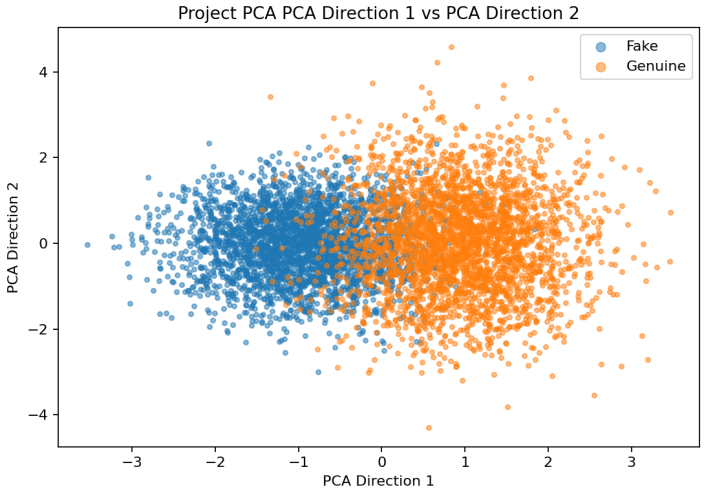


Figure 2: Scatter plot of the first two PCA directions. The geometric clusters of the original dataset are merely rotated; the classes remain heavily intertwined.

This confirms that exploratory analyses (like viewing 1D and 2D shadows of a 6D object) are often insufficient to understand global characteristics. To actually increase separability, a supervised approach is required. For instance, applying Linear Discriminant Analysis (LDA) specifically targets the direction that maximizes the distance between class means while minimizing intra-class variance. As seen below, the LDA projection successfully reveals a distinct shift between the classes that PCA's blind rotation could not achieve.

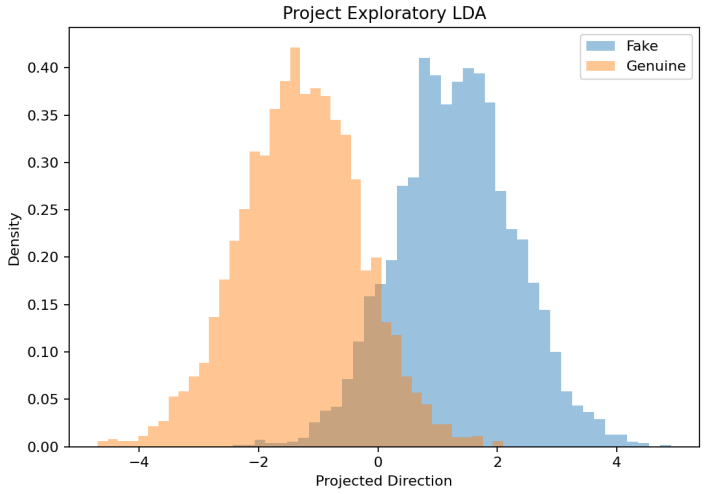


Figure 3: LDA Projection (1D). Unlike PCA, the supervised LDA projection clearly separates the density centers of the Fake and Genuine classes.

3 LDA analysis

Apply LDA and compute the histogram of the projected samples. What do you observe? Do the classes overlap over the found direction?

Observing the histogram of the samples projected onto the single LDA direction, we see a stark contrast to unsupervised methods like PCA. The data forms a clearly bimodal distribution with the "Fake" and "Genuine" classes occupying distinct regions of the projected space. However, the classes do still overlap over the found direction. The right tail of the "Fake" class intersects with the left tail of the "Genuine" class in the center. This indicates that while linear separability is significantly improved, a perfectly clean linear boundary that yields 0% error does not exist for this dataset.

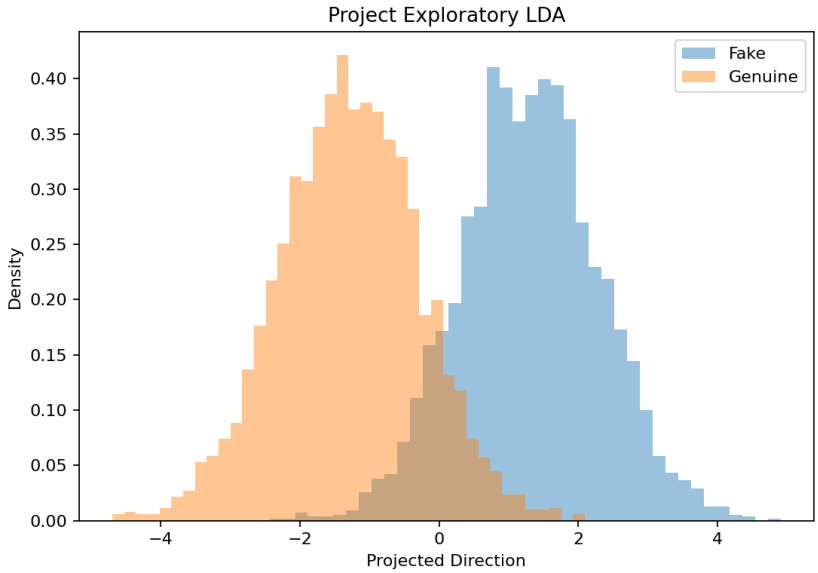


Figure 4: Histogram of the data projected onto the LDA direction. The density centers are separated, but the tails overlap.

Compared to the histograms of the 6 features you computed in Laboratory 2, is LDA finding a good direction with little class overlap?

Yes, LDA is finding an exceptionally good direction compared to the raw features. In Laboratory 2, the histograms of the 6 individual features showed massive overlap; the distributions for "Fake" and "Genuine" were often nearly superimposed (especially for features 1 and 2), meaning no single raw feature could act as a strong linear classifier. By taking a linear combination of all features, LDA successfully finds a 1-dimensional subspace where the class overlap is drastically minimized.

Try applying LDA for classification... Compute the predictions on the validation data, and the corresponding error rate.

We divided the dataset into a model training set and a validation set (containing 2000 samples). We applied LDA and oriented the projection so that the mean of the "Genuine" class was larger than the "Fake" class. Using the default threshold—the simple average of the two projected training class means, which was calculated as approximately -0.0185—the model achieved an error rate of **9.3%** on the validation data.

Now try changing the value of the threshold. What do you observe? Can you find values that improve the classification accuracy?

By sweeping the threshold across the range of projected values and evaluating the validation error at each step, we observe that the error rate forms a distinct curve with a clear minimum. The default geometric threshold (the midpoint of the projected means) does not yield the absolute lowest error.

We can indeed find values that improve classification accuracy. By shifting the threshold slightly lower to approximately -0.1080, the validation error rate improves, dropping from 9.3% down to **9.1%**. This observation suggests that the two class distributions are not perfectly symmetric or do not share the exact same variance; therefore, a slightly biased decision boundary discriminates the overlapping tails more effectively than the exact geometric midpoint.

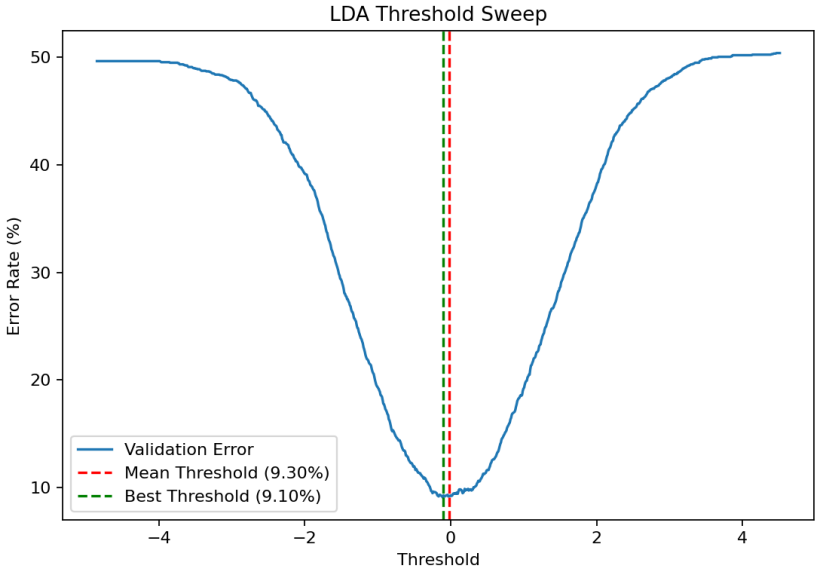


Figure 5: Validation error rate as a function of the classification threshold. The green dashed line indicates the empirical optimum, which achieves a slightly lower error rate (9.1%) than the default geometric mean threshold (9.3%, red dashed line).

4 PCA + LDA analysis

Apply PCA as a pre-processing step for LDA. Evaluate the error rate for different values of PCA dimensions ($m = 1, \ldots, 6$). What do you observe?

To evaluate the impact of PCA as a pre-processing step, we first project the data onto an m-dimensional PCA subspace, and subsequently apply LDA to reduce it to a single dimension for classification. The default threshold (average of the projected means) is used for evaluation on the validation set.

As shown in Table 1, varying the number of PCA dimensions (m) has virtually no impact on the classification performance. When we keep all dimensions ($m = 6$), the error rate perfectly matches the baseline pure LDA model at 9.30%. Aggressively reducing the dimensions down to $m = 2, 3$, or 4 yields a negligible shift to 9.25%, and reducing it to a single dimension ($m = 1$) yields 9.35%. Overall, the results are roughly identical across the board.

PCA Dimensions (m)	**Validation Error Rate (%)**
1	*9.35*
2	*9.25*
3	*9.25*
4	*9.25*
5	*9.30*
6	9.30

Table 1: Classification error rates using PCA as a pre-processing step for LDA across different subspace dimensions.

Does PCA pre-processing improve the classification accuracy? Why or why not?

No, PCA pre-processing does not significantly improve or degrade the classification accuracy for this dataset; we obtain roughly the same results regardless of the chosen dimensionality.

To deeply understand why PCA does not alter the LDA classification outcome, we must analyze the mathematical relationship between their optimization objectives.

Linear Discriminant Analysis (LDA) is a supervised method that seeks to find a projection that maximizes class separability. Mathematically, it does this by maximizing the between-class scatter matrix (S_B) while minimizing the within-class scatter matrix (S_W). Conceptually, it optimizes a ratio proportional to:

$$\text{LDA Objective} \propto \frac{S_B}{S_W}$$

Principal Component Analysis (PCA), on the other hand, is an unsupervised method that seeks to maximize the total variance of the entire dataset, represented by the total scatter matrix (S_T).

The fundamental link between these two algorithms is the scatter matrix identity:

$$S_T = S_B + S_W$$

This equation states that the total variance in the dataset (S_T) is exactly equal to the sum of the variance between the classes (S_B) and the variance within the classes (S_W).

If the within-class variance (S_W) is roughly fixed, isotropic (uniform in all directions), or relatively small, then the total scatter S_T becomes heavily dominated by S_B. In this mathematical scenario, when PCA searches for the directions of maximum total variance (S_T), it is inadvertently finding the directions of maximum between-class variance (S_B).

Because PCA and LDA are essentially aligning with the same fundamental variations in the data, dropping the "lowest variance" PCA dimensions only discards background noise, rather than discriminative information. When LDA is subsequently applied to this PCA-reduced subspace, it has access to the exact same discriminant directions it would have found in the raw feature space. Consequently, the pre-processing step is mathematically redundant, and the combination of PCA and LDA yields virtually identical error rates as using LDA alone.